he said, had to be jettisoned in favour of a modern curriculum that included ideas of liberalism and individual freedom. He derived many of his ideas from the tenets of Social Darwinism that were then current, and was influenced by British thinkers like Thomas Huxley, whose book *Evolution and Ethics* he translated into Chinese. At a later date, Yan Fu tried to justify the adoption of Western ideas and technology by arguing that most of these ideas could be found in classical Chinese texts but had not been followed up and developed. In adopting the new knowledge and philosophical systems, therefore, China was going back to its own roots and there was a convergence between Chinese and Western knowledge systems. This was a line taken by several Chinese scholars in justifying reforms, reflecting the perennial paradox – that Western superiority, while being irresistible, was also very hard to acknowledge, given the long-entrenched assumption of China's centrality. There were any number of scholars who strained to find in Chinese classical texts references that demonstrated Chinese familiarity with many Western ideas and techniques. China was also encountering, in the West, Westphalian nation-states, where national identity was closely linked to the articulation of a strong and often glorified national history. Therefore it followed that to build a strong and modern China there must be an affirmation of a glorious history that admits to no weakness. This tendency is visible in Chinese writings around the end of the nineteenth and the beginning of the twentieth centuries. A similar phenomenon may be found in other countries, including India, which were struggling to throw off the colonial yoke. The curated recalling of a glorious past became part and parcel of the struggle to come to terms with Western power.

It was after the defeat of China by Japan in 1894 and the conclusion of the humiliating Shimonoseki Treaty in 1895 that pressure built up for more radical reforms and when the views of scholars like Yan Fu found greater currency. A large number of young scholars had gathered in Beijing to take part in the annual civil service examination when the treaty was announced. They were deeply offended by the humiliating terms imposed on China. This also marks the birth of a Chinese nationalism.

The scholars submitted appeals to the Qing court demanding more radical